

“I've seen a lot of dirty operations in Third World countries. The most shocking was seeing all this post-consumption waste.”

Jim Puckett, re

Where lies the responsibility

A problem that can be much more rampant than the pollution caused by displays or micro chips, is that of printer reusable products. Printer cartridges are discarded once they are used, and not much care is taken to provide proper facilities for their recycling. The cartridges contain chemicals that are extremely hazardous. Black toners contain substances such as carbon black that are carcinogenic and cause respiratory tract irritations. Also, colour toners (CMY) may contain heavy metal elements.

In the US and Europe, IT companies such as IBM, Dell and Intel have commitments to ensure environmental safety. However, there are no visible assurances in India. Clearly, environmental laws are a major factor in these efforts. For example, AMD maintains the goal of a lead free development program. In response to the deadline of July 1, 2006 set by the European Community, National Semiconductor has a detailed Corporate Environment, Health and Safety (EHS) policy. The company has recycling programs for process water, chemicals, lubricants, paper, packaging materials, and scrap products. The process water is used for irrigation or cooling. Chemicals are reused, or burned for energy. National Semiconductor also uses a method of recognising and rewarding employees for recycling programs. It has also issued various certificates for various processes, which come under scrutiny for safety of the environment. Intel also has a complete EHS policy, which entails the safety standards observed for all manufacturing process. They also address issues such as computer recycling—Intel has created an online product ecology centre, which can be accessed for information as regards computer recycling. The listings can be used to determine an effective way of disposing your PC. However, they do not provide India-specific information.

On the fifth of June, HP embarked on the Planet Partners Return and Recycling Program. The target is to eradicate the problem of cartridge dumping. The



program will initially target its Most Valued Customers (MVCs), spread across a network of 42 cities and towns. Information about the program and the adverse effects of unsafe dumping is being sent to the MVCs via mailers or direct contacts. Parikshit Tomar, Marketing Manager of the supplies business of HP says, “HP is fulfilling its moral obligation to society. The services provided by HP will be absolutely free of cost.” If MVCs have any interest in the program, the logistics team of HP periodically collects the used printer supplies and recycles them in proper facilities. HP also plans to develop its participant base in the future to accommodate the common customer. It is hoped that initiatives such as this will pave the way for a cleaner and greener technology roadmap.

But what was

the solution to the growing problems of waste from the electronic world is still not clear. This is because the fact that electronic waste is very real, and becoming a large threat to the environment is ungraspable. The new age business cannot have a squeaky-clean image.

A move that could rapidly clean up the growing waste problem would be to identify and make manufacturing units responsible for the entire lifecycle of the product. When a product becomes defunct, the producer must not shirk its responsibility. If a corporation is made liable for its own products, it can use its economic power to effectively recycle its products. Also, since this model of recycling becomes product dependent, the manufacturer will be able to recycle the product with maximum efficiency. 

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